

later languages of East or Central Asia were relying on modern readings of Chinese characters, or in a few limited cases, on the outdated reconstruction of Old Chinese (OC) by Karlgren. It was, of course, a doomed enterprise from the start, as the Chinese phonology underwent tremendous changes during last two thousand years. Thus, it could be compared to an attempt to phonologically interpret a language X, written two thousand years ago by means of the Greek alphabet, through the prism of modern Greek phonology. Therefore, Pulleyblank's hypothesis, whether it finally proves right or wrong, was a significant step forward methodologically, as it is based on author's reconstruction of Old Chinese phonology, that itself represents a considerable advance compared to Karlgren's reconstruction.³

The goal of the present article is to evaluate Pulleyblank's arguments from the point of view of further advances in the reconstruction of Old Chinese and in the historical-comparative and descriptive study of Yeniseian languages. Since 1962 there has been a considerable progress in both the reconstruction of Old Chinese and, more importantly, in the reconstruction and description of Yeniseian languages. Thus, many of the materials on the latter, unavailable to Pulleyblank at that time, can be utilized now. As far as Old Chinese phonology is concerned, I will rely on the version of Old Chinese reconstruction, recently proposed in Starostin 1989 and Baxter 1991, rather than on Pulleyblank's own reconstructions. For the sources on Yeniseian reconstruction, I will use Sergei Starostin's comparative phonology (1982) and comparative vocabulary (1995) of Yeniseian, and Georgii Starostin's reconstruction of Proto-Yeniseian verbal system (1995). Several important descriptive studies of Yeniseian languages have also been consulted or used: Dulson's Ket grammar (1968) and, Vall and Kanakin's phonology and morphology of Ket (1990), Kreinovich's monograph on Ket verb (1968a), sketch of Ket (1968b), and sketch of Yug (1979), Werner's grammar of Kott (1990) and

³ It must be noted, however, that since 1962, Pulleyblank has changed his views considerably on the reconstruction of Old Chinese, sometimes taking even an agnostic position on prospects of Old Chinese reconstruction (Pulleyblank 1973, 1991, 1992, 1994). His new version of Old Chinese does not seem to enjoy the same kind of scholarly support as did his earlier version.